



Combat Mindset — Proposed Way Forward

Joint NZALC and Human Performance Cell response to COMDT ACS

HARDER TO KILL

Proposed Warfighter Focus line — subject to sponsor endorsement

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Purpose

This paper responds to COMDT ACS direction of 16 July 2026 for NZALC and the Human Performance Cell to jointly develop a strategy to close the Combat Mindset doctrine and policy gap. It proposes an agreed problem statement, formal definitions and their relationship for decision, the Army Combat Mindset Framework as the organising model, a programme of work, interim governance and assurance arrangements, and the appropriate nesting of existing training products beneath the framework.

1. The problem

Army does not currently have an endorsed, Army-wide definition, doctrine, governance or assurance model for Combat Mindset, despite the term being in active use and despite Army's drive toward an increased Warfighter Focus. The COMDT ACS guidance and the NZALC capability note reach the same diagnosis:

Substantial relevant capability already exists across ACS, NZALC, the Human Performance Cell, NZDF Psychology, ILD, training establishments and force employers. The challenge is not primarily a lack of content. It is a lack of visibility, integration, common terminology, strategic ownership and assurance across that existing capability.

The underlying operational problem remains as stated in the NZALC capability note:

Under operational pressure, trained individuals and teams do not always retain access to their full capability.

The doctrinal requirement is therefore to define the human-performance capability Army must deliberately develop, and to describe its combat-specific expression.

Sufficient evidence and existing capability are available to commence governance, mapping and framework development immediately. The present gap is principally institutional and integrative.

2. Terminology and definitions — decision sought

The COMDT ACS guidance and the NZALC capability note differ on one structural point: the relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure. This is the single decision required before the framework can be drafted. Two options are offered.

Option 1 — Combat Mindset as the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure (recommended)

Combat Mindset is the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure. It describes the individual and collective readiness and disposition Army seeks under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat.

Performance Under Pressure is the enabling human-performance capability: the trainable individual and collective capacity to prepare for, maintain effective performance through, adapt within and recover from pressure. It is applicable across combat, command, crisis response, training, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity. Combat Mindset places that broader capability within its specifically warfighting context and connects it to Army's mission, identity, values and operational purpose.

The Army Combat Mindset Framework is the organising model through which Army will define, develop, integrate and assure the capability pillars, developmental outcomes, training products and governance arrangements that enable this effect.

The following formal definitions are proposed as the drafting baseline.

Combat Mindset. *The combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure: the individual and collective readiness and disposition to remain effective and act decisively, persistently, adaptively and ethically under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat in order to achieve the mission.*

Performance Under Pressure. *The trainable individual and collective human-performance capability to prepare for, maintain effective performance through, adapt within and recover from conditions that create significant physiological, cognitive, emotional or social interference.*

Army Combat Mindset Framework. *The organising model through which Army defines, develops, integrates and assures the individual and collective capabilities that enable Combat Mindset.*

Performance Under Pressure describes the trainable human-performance capability. Combat Mindset describes the specifically combat-oriented expression of that capability.

- Gives each term one clear purpose: Combat Mindset is the combat-specific expression; Performance Under Pressure is the enabling capability; the Army Combat Mindset Framework is the organising model.
- Keeps Performance Under Pressure applicable wherever significant pressure exists without an enemy — command, crisis response, training, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity.
- Guards against Combat Mindset being misread as aggression, motivation or resilience alone.
- Harder to Kill remains a proposed Warfighter Focus communication line, subject to sponsor endorsement, and does not form part of the formal definitions.

Option 2 — Combat Mindset as the complete umbrella capability

Combat Mindset is treated as the complete capability itself, integrating leadership, human performance, resilience, mental skills and performance cognition, with performance under pressure expressed within it.

- Maximises simplicity: one term serves as outcome, capability and framework alike.

- Conflates the combat-specific outcome with the broader human-performance capability, reducing applicability outside combat.
- Makes it difficult to distinguish doctrine, capability, framework and product.
- Increases the risk that Combat Mindset is interpreted as motivation or aggression alone.

Both options deliver the end state described in the COMDT ACS guidance. NZALC and HPC jointly recommend Option 1, and will implement whichever option COMDT ACS selects.

3. What already exists

A full capability and product map will be completed during Phase 1. The products described below contribute to the development of Performance Under Pressure and, where applied in a warfighting context, to Combat Mindset. They do not constitute the doctrinal definitions or the complete framework in isolation. Initial holdings include the following.

NZALC Performance Under Pressure package

NZALC delivers a leadership-development approach incorporating Performance = Potential – Interference, Red Head–Blue Head, Prepare–Perform–Recover, mental-skills techniques, psychometrics, experiential activity, feedback and Leadership Development Plans. This material is embedded across Lead Self, Lead Teams, Lead Leaders and Lead Systems.

Human Performance Cell Cognitive Conditioning programme (COGCON)

COGCON is a developmental cognitive-conditioning product designed to train selected dimensions of performance cognition under physical and cognitive load: arousal regulation, attention, cognitive control, working memory, performance monitoring and self-knowledge. Its most mature and potentially scalable component is an adaptive dual-task training module combining a tablet-based cognitive task with a concurrent job-relevant information task, progressive difficulty and performance feedback.

COGCON has demonstrated feasibility, participant acceptability and promising training trends in limited military cohorts. It has not yet been validated as a measure of operational readiness or proven through controlled research to improve real-world military performance. Its current status is therefore that of an emerging, evidence-informed training product rather than an endorsed Army-wide capability system.

NZDF Psychology, ILD and other stakeholders

These organisations hold additional professional expertise, learning products, delivery capability and assurance functions that will be confirmed during Phase 1 mapping.

Initial review indicates considerable conceptual alignment across existing products. The Army Combat Mindset Framework will establish a common doctrinal language beneath which individual products and methods can be appropriately nested. It will not require all products to use identical internal methodologies, provided they align to the endorsed framework, outcomes and assurance requirements.

4. COGCON minimum viable product

For the purposes of the Combat Mindset programme of work, COGCON will initially be treated as a developmental minimum viable product within the performance-cognition pillar of the Army Combat Mindset Framework, contributing to selected elements of Performance Under Pressure.

The COGCON MVP comprises:

- a short adaptive dual-task activity embedded within existing physical or military training;
- a tablet-delivered attention and inhibition task;
- a concurrent prerecorded operational information task, such as an audio brief;
- immediate recall questions or objective job-task scoring;
- controlled difficulty levels and defined progression criteria;
- selected arousal-regulation techniques;
- basic performance feedback and longitudinal training records; and
- a train-the-trainer and assurance package allowing delivery by existing training staff.

The MVP does not constitute:

- a standalone Army course;
- a complete Combat Mindset or Performance Under Pressure programme;
- a selection, promotion or diagnostic tool;
- a validated measure of operational readiness; or
- a commitment for HPC personnel to deliver the product across Army.

HPC will retain technical stewardship of the COGCON method and provide specialist advice, product development, train-the-trainer support and proportionate assurance within available capacity. Routine delivery, if subsequently approved, will be undertaken through existing training establishments, instructors and physical-training staff.

5. Proposed programme of work

Phase 0 — Governance and definition (by end July 2026)

Confirm interim sponsorship and capability-integration arrangements, endorse the problem statement, select the terminology option at paragraph 2, and draft for staffing the Army-endorsed definitions of Combat Mindset, Performance Under Pressure and the Army Combat Mindset Framework, together with the agreed relationship between the three.

Phase 1 — Capability and product mapping (August 2026)

Map existing doctrine, content, products, courses, instructor capability, delivery activity, evidence, ownership and assurance arrangements across ACS, NZALC, HPC, NZDF

Psychology, ILD, training establishments and selected force employers. The mapping will distinguish:

- doctrinal and policy holdings;
- capability outcomes;
- training products and methods;
- delivery organisations;
- technical and professional authorities;
- evidence maturity;
- scalability and resource requirements; and
- gaps, duplication and integration opportunities.

The mapping will identify which products contribute to the broader Performance Under Pressure capability and which support its combat-specific expression. COGCON will be assessed as one developmental product within this map, with particular attention to its MVP boundary, evidence base — including its completed feasibility trials in live military training — ownership, workforce requirements and scalability.

Phase 2 — Framework and product architecture (September 2026)

Draft the Army Combat Mindset Framework as the organising model through which Army will define, develop, integrate and assure Performance Under Pressure and its combat-specific expression. The framework will include the endorsed definitions and desired operational effect; the integrated capability pillars; developmental outcomes from Lead Self through Lead Systems; the relationship between doctrine, framework, products and delivery; common assurance principles; and the criteria by which existing and future products may be recognised as contributing to the framework.

Existing products, including the NZALC Performance Under Pressure package and the COGCON MVP, will be mapped beneath the relevant capability pillars rather than treated as the framework itself.

Phase 3 — Stakeholder forum (September 2026)

Convene ACS, NZALC, HPC, NZDF Psychology, ILD, selected training providers and force employers to refine the framework, product architecture, governance model, implementation priorities, definition clarity and doctrinal coherence.

Phase 4 — Report back (November 2026)

Present the endorsed definitions and the confirmed relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure; Framework v1.0 and its agreed architecture; the validated capability and product map; the proposed governance and assurance model; and a prioritised implementation plan. The report will identify whether COGCON should remain a developmental product; undergo further controlled evaluation; be integrated selectively into existing training; be prepared for broader scaling; or cease or change direction.

6. Governance

The following arrangements are proposed for confirmation at Phase 0. Technical and professional authority is distributed by domain; no single organisation owns the evidence base for the entire capability.

- Army Sponsor — strategic sponsor for Combat Mindset, the enabling Performance Under Pressure capability and the Army Combat Mindset Framework.
- Interim capability integrator — COMDT ACS, coordinating definition, framework development, stakeholder engagement and recommendations to the Army Sponsor.
- Capability development and delivery coordinator — ACS, coordinating the framework, developmental architecture and recognised training products, leveraging NZALC and wider ACS expertise, intellectual property and programmes.
- COGCON product steward and performance-cognition adviser — Human Performance Cell, responsible for the integrity and further development of the COGCON method and for specialist advice on cognitive conditioning and proportionate measurement, within available capacity.
- Domain advisers and authorities — NZDF Psychology, ILD, physical-performance specialists, doctrine staff and other relevant organisations, providing technical or professional advice within their respective domains.
- Delivery agencies — training establishments, units and existing instructor workforces approved to deliver recognised products.
- Assurance — a layered assurance model covering doctrine, evidence, professional content, learning design, delivery quality and operational relevance, with sufficient independence from individual product owners and delivery organisations.

7. Recommendations

It is recommended that COMDT ACS:

1. **Endorse the problem statement** at paragraph 1.
2. **Endorse Combat Mindset as the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure**, and Performance Under Pressure as the enabling, trainable individual and collective human-performance capability.
3. **Endorse the formal definitions** at paragraph 2 as the baseline for staffing.
4. **Endorse the Army Combat Mindset Framework** as the organising model through which Army will define, develop, integrate and assure the capabilities, products and governance arrangements that enable Combat Mindset.
5. **Note that existing programmes and products will be mapped beneath the framework's capability pillars** and will not constitute the framework in isolation.
6. **Endorse COGCON's interim status as a developmental MVP** within the performance-cognition pillar.
7. **Confirm the governance model** at paragraph 6, including COMDT ACS as interim capability integrator pending confirmation of the Army Sponsor, and HPC as COGCON product steward and performance-cognition adviser.
8. **Approve the programme of work** at paragraph 5, including capability and product mapping, framework development and stakeholder engagement.
9. **Direct that the November 2026 report provide** the endorsed definitions and confirmed relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure; Framework v1.0 and its agreed architecture; the validated capability and product map; a governance and assurance model; an assessment of COGCON's evidence, scalability, resource requirements and appropriate future role; and a prioritised implementation plan.

Annex A — Initial capability and product architecture

A1. Doctrinal hierarchy

Hierarchy	Composition
Warfighting imperative	Individuals, teams and leaders remain effective and act decisively, persistently, adaptively and ethically under combat conditions
Combat-specific expression	Combat Mindset
Enabling human-performance capability	Performance Under Pressure
Organising model	Army Combat Mindset Framework
Capability pillars	Leadership; mental skills; performance cognition; resilience and recovery; physical performance; professional identity and values; individual and collective exposure to pressure
Training products and methods	NZALC Performance Under Pressure package; COGCON MVP; NZDF Psychology products; scenario and experiential training; physical conditioning; structured reflection and recovery; other products identified during Phase 1 mapping

Warfighting imperative → Combat Mindset → enabled by Performance Under Pressure → developed and organised through the Army Combat Mindset Framework → delivered through capability pillars, products and methods

A2. COGCON current nesting

Attribute	COGCON current position
Capability pillar	Performance cognition
Primary level	Individual / Lead Self
Secondary applicability	Selected Lead Teams activity
Product status	Developmental MVP
Relationship to Combat Mindset	Develops selected elements of Performance Under Pressure that may contribute to Combat Mindset when integrated within broader warfighting, leadership, values, physical and collective development
Current contribution	Arousal regulation, attention, cognitive control, working memory, performance monitoring and adaptive dual-task conditioning
Current evidence	Feasibility, acceptability and promising training trends
Not yet established	Causal effectiveness, far transfer, operational-readiness validity and Army-wide scalability
Product steward	Human Performance Cell

Attribute	COGCON current position
Likely delivery model	Existing instructors or physical-training staff following standardisation and train-the-trainer preparation
Assurance	HPC for COGCON product integrity; broader framework assurance through the agreed governance system

A3. Division of functions

Function	Lead	Output
Define and govern	Army Sponsor / ACS	Endorsed doctrine, definitions, policy direction and capability outcomes
Integrate capability	ACS	Framework, product architecture, stakeholder coordination and implementation priorities
Develop products	Relevant product owner	Product design, protocols, instructor materials and updates
Provide domain advice	Relevant technical or professional adviser	Specialist advice within leadership, psychology, cognition, learning design, physical performance and other domains
Deliver	Approved training establishments, units and existing instructor workforces	Routine delivery of recognised products
Measure training performance	Delivery organisation, using approved methods	Proportionate training feedback and product-level performance data
Evaluate product effectiveness	Product owner, with independent evaluation or research support	Evidence of feasibility, effectiveness, transfer and scalability
Assure	Layered governance and domain authorities	Doctrine, evidence, professional, learning, delivery and operational assurance
Review and recover	Relevant leadership and training systems	Reflection, feedback, recovery and developmental planning

A4. Shared developmental models

- Prepare–Perform–Recover provides a common developmental and delivery rhythm across recognised products and methods.
- Lead Self to Lead Systems provides the developmental progression from individual capability to collective, leadership and systems application: individual conditioning is

likely to be densest in initial and individual training, while leadership, team and systems application deepens across the leadership continuum.

- COGCON currently contributes principally to selected Prepare and Perform activities within the performance-cognition pillar. NZALC and other leadership-development products provide broader preparation, application, structured review and recovery.